Yara M. Damaj

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EDUCATION

PhD (expected Spring 2026), Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania

MA (2021), Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania

MA (2017) in Public Policy and International Affairs, Department of Political Studies, American University of Beirut
Thesis: "The Islamic State and the Necromancy of the Mundane"
Committee: Nadia Bou Ali (Chair), Ahmad Dallal, and Samer Frangieh

BA (2014), Departments of Political Studies and Psychology (double major), American University of Beirut
Minor in Human Rights and Transitional Justice

DISSERTATION

"Lebanese Nostalgia: A Study in Postcolonial Subject Formation"

Committee: Roxanne L. Euben (Chair), Anne Norton (Supervisor), Marwan M. Kraidy, Eve Troutt Powell, and Jeffrey Green

A political-theoretical analysis of nostalgia as an affective structure that shapes postcolonial subjectivity in Lebanon under neoliberal capitalism and its crises.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Critical theory, postcolonial theory, feminist political thought, affect theory, Middle East politics, historical materialism, cultural critique, and psychoanalytic approaches

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Articles

Saad, G., Damaj, Y., Tabaja, M., and DeJong, J. (2021). "Critical Assessment of Typologies of Conflict and their Relevance to Public Health Research." *International Journal of Epidemiology*, 50.

Damaj, Y. M. (2020). "Islamic State: Politics by Other Means?" *International Journal of Communication* [Online], 14(16).

Public Writing

Damaj, Y. M. (2019). "Fatal Attraction: The Islamic State's Politics of Sentimentality." *CARG Briefs Volume I: ISIS Media*.

Damaj, Y. M. (2017). "Fatal Attraction: The Islamic State's Politics of Sentimentality." *Global-e*, 10(63).

Damaj, Y. M. (2017). "Beyond Disbelief: ISIS and the Politics of Recognition." *Civilization*, Saleh Barakat Gallery.

FELLOWSHIPS AND GRANTS

Fellowships

Academic Engagement Fellowship, Middle East Center, University of Pennsylvania (2025)

Graduate Fellowship, Andrea Mitchell Center for the Study of Democracy, University of Pennsylvania (2024–2025)

Boies Family Fellowship, University of Pennsylvania (2024–2025)

Invited Senior Graduate Fellow for Inclusive and Equitable Teaching, Center for Excellence in Teaching, Learning, and Innovation, University of Pennsylvania (2024–2025)

Graduate Fellowship for Inclusive and Equitable Teaching, Center for Excellence in Teaching, Learning, and Innovation, University of Pennsylvania (2023–2024)

Samuel H. Preston Fellowship, University of Pennsylvania (2020–2021)

Philosophy of Finance Fellowship, Collegium Institute, University of Pennsylvania (2020–2021)

Benjamin Franklin Fellowship, University of Pennsylvania (2018–2023)

Graduate Assistantship, Issam Fares Institute, and Faculty of Arts and Sciences, American University of Beirut (2015–2017)

Research Grants

Summer Research Grant, Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania (2021, 2022, 2023, 2024)

Research Grant, Christopher H. Browne Center for International Politics, University of Pennsylvania (2019)

Turner-Schulman Fellowship, Center for the Study of Ethnicity, Race, and Immigration, University of Pennsylvania (2019)

Travel and Conference Grants

SAS Dean's Travel Subvention Award, University of Pennsylvania (2022, 2023, 2025)

Research Student Travel Grant, Graduate and Professional Student Assembly, University of Pennsylvania (2023, 2024, 2025)

School of Arts and Sciences Government Travel and Research Grant, University of Pennsylvania (2019, 2020, 2024)

Graduate Conference and Training Grant, Center for the Study of Ethnicity, Race, and Immigration, University of Pennsylvania (2019, 2023)

Conference Travel Grant, Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania (2022)

Additional Support

SAS Graduate Division Funding, University of Pennsylvania (2023–2024)

Partial Scholarship, Critical Theory Workshop, France (2018)

Housing Scholarship, TOMidEast Program, University of Turin (2016)

AWARDS

Academic

Alvin Z. Rubinstein Memorial Award for Excellence in Teaching by a Graduate Student, Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania (2022)

Service

Team Leadership Award, College Houses and Academic Services, University of Pennsylvania (2022, 2023)

Creativity and Innovation Award, College Houses and Academic Services, University of Pennsylvania (2022)

TEACHING

University of Pennsylvania

Undergraduate Teaching in Political Science

Instructor of Record, Modern Political Thought (Fall 2021)

Teaching Assistant, Modern Political Thought (Spring 2020, Spring 2021)

Teaching Assistant, Politics in the Contemporary Middle East (Fall 2020)

Teaching Assistant, Political Change in the Third World (Fall 2019)

Grader, Networks and NGOs in World Politics (Spring 2024)

Grader, Political Action and Dissent (Fall 2021)

Graduate and Postdoctoral Pedagogical Training

Instructor of Record, Mini Course in Inclusive and Equitable Teaching (Fall 2023)

TA Trainer for Inclusive and Equitable Teaching (Fall 2023)

RESEARCH

Research Consultant, Faculty of Health Sciences, American University of Beirut (2018)

Research Assistant, Dr. Rim Saab, Department of Psychology, American University of Beirut (2014)

Research Assistant, Political Trauma Project, Drs. Lina and Mahmoud Kreidie (2013–2014)

Research Assistant, Faculty of Engineering, American University of Beirut (2013)

Intern, The Daily Star, Lebanon (2014)

Student Worker, The Writing Center, American University of Beirut (2013–2014)

PRESENTATIONS

Conference Presentations

"The Only Way Forward is Backwards: Nostalgia, Neoliberalism, and the End of Politics." Political Theory Internal Workshop, University of Pennsylvania (2025)

"Singing the Nation into Being: Nostalgia, Resilience and Belonging in Fairuz's Work." Western Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Seattle, WA (2025)

"Humor and Politics: Dispatches from the Lebanese Crisis." Crisis, Capitalism, and the Temporality of Resistance Panel, Graduate Workshop, Andrea Mitchell Center, University of Pennsylvania (2024)

"Back to the Future: Nostalgia, Repetition, and the False Promise of Capitalism." 21st Annual Historical Materialism Conference, London, United Kingdom (2024)

"Double Trouble: #MosqueMeToo and the Subject of Feminism." Gender, Sexuality, and Women's Studies Graduate Colloquium, University of Pennsylvania (2023)

"On Humor: Dispatches from the Lebanese Crisis." Western Political Science Association Annual Meeting, San Francisco, CA (2023)

"Double Trouble: #MosqueMeToo and the Subject of Feminism." Western Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Portland, OR (2022)

"Which Came First, the People or the Egg? The Politics of Representation in Lebanon's 'October Revolution.'" Middle East Studies Association Annual Meeting, virtual (2020)

"At the Intersection: Migrant Domestic Workers in Lebanon" (poster). Turner-Schulmann Fellows Poster Presentations, Center for the Study of Ethnicity, Race, and Immigration, University of Pennsylvania (2019)

"Disrupting Binaries: #MosqueMeToo, Double Duress, and Colonial Mimicry." Political Theory Internal Workshop, University of Pennsylvania (2019)

"At the Intersection: Migrant Domestic Workers in Lebanon." 16th Annual Historical Materialism Conference, London, United Kingdom (2019)

"The Islamic State: Politics by Other Means." Mediating the Islamic State Symposium, Center for Advanced Research in Global Communication, University of Pennsylvania (2018)

Invited Talks

"How to be an Assertive Leader." Winter Summit, College Houses and Academic Services, University of Pennsylvania (2022)

"Disrupting Binaries: #MosqueMeToo, Double Bind, and Colonial Mimicry." Middle East Center, University of Pennsylvania (2020)

"Fatal Attraction: The Islamic State's Politics of Sentimentality." Emerging Work on Communicative Dimensions of Islamic State, Jihadi Networks of Communication and Cultures Research Group (JINCS), Center for Advanced Research in Global Communication, University of Pennsylvania (2017)

"ISIS Media Strategies." Challenging Conventional Wisdom: The Economics of Migration and Public Perception Workshop, Issam Fares Institute and LSE International Global Affairs INET Young Scholars Initiative @AUB, American University of Beirut (2017)

Public Engagement

Interviewer, Andrea Mitchell Center Podcast. "Crossing the Line: Finding America at the Borderlands" (2025)

Interviewer, Andrea Mitchell Center Podcast. "The Path Ahead for Syrian Reconstruction" (2025)

Speaker, "Beyond the Headlines: Assessing Lebanon's Present and Future." Emerging Scholars Speaker Series, Middle East Center, University of Pennsylvania (2025)

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

Academic Service

Co-Organizer, "Affect and Politics Colloquium," Andrea Mitchell Center, University of Pennsylvania (2025)

Co-Organizer, "Graduate Student Workshop Series," Andrea Mitchell Center for the Study of Democracy, University of Pennsylvania (2024–2025)

Panel Chair, "Global Political Thought-Struggle, Ideology & Cosmology," Western Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Seattle, WA (2025)

Organizer and Host, "The Future of DEI? A Conversation with Michelle Kimberly Johnson," Andrea Mitchell Center for the Study of Democracy, University of Pennsylvania (2024)

Discussant, Political Theory Workshop, University of Pennsylvania (2023)

Panelist, Admitted Graduate Students Day, Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania (2022)

Panelist, "Desserts and Dissertations," College Houses and Academic Services, University of Pennsylvania (2022)

Co-Coordinator, Political Theory Workshop, University of Pennsylvania (2020–2021)

Co-Organizer, "Producing Politics: Spaces of Contestation in Lebanon Today" Panel, Middle East Studies Association Annual Meeting, virtual (2020)

Discussant, Andrea Mitchell Center "Capitalism/Socialism/Democracy" Inaugural Series Lecture, University of Pennsylvania (2019)

Member, PhD Methods Requirement Student Committee, Political Science Department, University of Pennsylvania (2019–2021)

Co-Representative, Department of Political Science, School of Arts and Sciences Government, University of Pennsylvania (2019–2020)

Organizing Member, Political Science Graduate Student Conference, University of Pennsylvania (2019–2020)

Administrative and Research Assistant, Joint Project for a Master's in Global Health and Sustainable Development, American University of Beirut, Lebanon, and EARTH University, Costa Rica (2014–2015)

Panel Chair, Beirut Historical Materialism Conference, Beirut Institute for Critical Analysis and Research and the Center for Arts and Humanities, American University of Beirut (2017)

Advising and Mentoring

Acting Advisor for Undergraduate Studies, Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania (January–February 2023)

Interim Advisor for Undergraduate Studies, Department of Political Science, University of Pennsylvania (January–September 2022)

University Governance and Leadership

Member, RA Awards Selection Committee, College Houses and Academic Services, University of Pennsylvania (2025)

Representative of the International Affairs Committee at the House Committee, Perry World House, University of Pennsylvania (2020)

Member, Public Affairs Committee, School of Arts and Sciences Graduate Student Government, University of Pennsylvania (2019–2020)

Board Member, International Affairs Committee, Graduate and Professional Student Assembly, University of Pennsylvania (2019–2021)

Graduate Resident Advisor, Harnwell College House, College Houses and Academic Services, University of Pennsylvania (2020–present)

Graduate Resident Advisor, Arts House Program, Harnwell College House, College Houses and Academic Services, University of Pennsylvania (2020–2021)

Civic Leadership

Project Director, "International People's Project," CISV Lebanon (Summer 2017)

Member and Change Maker, National Committee on the Follow-Up on Women's Issues, Lebanon (2014–2015)

National Association Representative for Lebanon, CISV International (2014–2017)

Acting Trustee, CISV Lebanon (2014)

Elected Board Member, CISV Lebanon (2011–2014)

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Participant, "Critique and the Desire for Modernity" Summer School, Beirut Institute for Critical Analysis and Research, Lebanon (2022)

Participant, London Critical Theory Summer School, Birkbeck University of London, United Kingdom (2019)

Independent Researcher, University of Oxford, United Kingdom, mentored by Dr. Faisal Devji (Summer 2019)

Participant, Critical Theory Workshop, France (Summer 2018)

Participant, TOMidEast Summer School, University of Turin, Italy (Summer 2017)

Participant, U.S. Foreign Policy Summer Program, Elliott School of International Affairs, George Washington University, United States (Summer 2017)

Participant, International Humanitarian Law Course, Lebanese Army, Lebanon (Summer 2014)

Participant, Seventh Annual Inter-University Programme on International Law and Procedure, Asser Institute and the Outreach and Legacy Section of the Special Tribunal for Lebanon (2012–2013)

Student, Sciences Po Paris, France (Fall 2012)

Student, Oxford Royale Academy, University of Oxford (Summer 2009)

LANGUAGES

Arabic (Native); English (Full Fluency); French (Full Fluency); Spanish (Intermediate); Greek (Beginner)